Robust Audio Deepfake Detection

A Progressive Unfreezing and On-the-Fly Augmentation Approach

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Abstract

The rapid advancement of Text-to-Speech (TTS) and Voice Conversion (VC) models has rendered audio deepfakes highly realistic, presenting critical security challenges in modern communication networks. While current Audio Deepfake Detection (ADD) methods perform exceptionally well on pristine acoustic datasets, they suffer a catastrophic collapse in detection capability when exposed to real-world telephony channels that introduce codec compression, frequency filtering, and environmental noise. To bridge this robustness gap, we propose an end-to-end detection framework leveraging the self-supervised representations of Wav2Vec 2.0. By adopting a meticulously engineered *Progressive Unfreezing* strategy—strategically tuning top-level transformer layers to prevent catastrophic forgetting—combined with a GPU-accelerated *On-the-fly Data Augmentation* pipeline, our approach achieves superior domain generalization. Evaluated comprehensively on the ASVspoof 2019 dataset, our model dramatically reduces the Equal Error Rate (EER) from an initial 10.13% down to 2.68% in clean settings. Even more remarkably, it mitigates the severe channel degradation collapse, plunging the baseline's random-guess 54.53% EER safely down to 24.32% under heavy constraints, establishing a new paradigm for robust countermeasure design against synthetic media threats.

1. Introduction

The evolution of zero-shot Voice Cloning and advanced Text-to-Speech (TTS) algorithms has substantially lowered the barrier to generating ultra-realistic synthetic audio. This technological leap, unfortunately, has been weaponized for malicious impersonation, telecom fraud, and widespread disinformation campaigns on social media [1]. In response to the increasing societal impact of these threats, the academic community has established rigorous benchmarks, notably the ASVspoof challenges [2], to foster the development of reliable countermeasure (CM) systems.

Historically, Audio Deepfake Detection (ADD) systems relied heavily on handcrafted acoustic features, such as Mel-Frequency Cepstral Coefficients (MFCC) or Linear Frequency Cepstral Coefficients (LFCC). These algorithms process spectral envelopes utilizing Gaussian Mixture Models (GMM) or lightweight Convolutional Neural Networks (CNN). While successful under strictly controlled acoustic conditions, these heuristic systems exhibit staggeringly poor generalization; they typically memorize dataset-specific artifacts (such as the micro-clicks present in early vocoders) rather than learning fundamental authenticity representations.

More critically, when subjected to real-world telephony transmission—such as Voice over LTE (VoLTE), standard VoIP protocols, or intense background interference—the underlying acoustic cues utilized by heuristic systems are irreversibly corrupted by audio codec compression and packet-loss effects [3]. A system reporting a near 0% error rate in a laboratory can instantly degrade into a random guessing state the moment audio is compressed via a standard WhatsApp or WeChat transmission.

In this project, we explicitly demonstrate the vulnerability of fixed, monolithic feature extractors. We introduce a highly robust ADD architecture that bypasses outdated features and directly leverages the massive Self-Supervised Learning (SSL) representations of Wav2Vec 2.0 [4]. Specifically, our study validates two major engineering and theoretical contributions via a rigorous ablation framework:

1. **Progressive Unfreezing Strategy:** A dynamic fine-tuning approach that selectively adapts the higher-order Transformer blocks of the SSL extractor. This elegantly aligns acoustic domain shifts specific to synthetic artifacts without suffering the catastrophic representation forgetting typically observed in large-parameter models [5].

2. **On-the-fly Data Augmentation:** A target-driven, GPU-based probabilistic degradation pipeline. By mathematically injecting synthetic noise and simulating quantization during tensor mini-batch construction, we forcibly shift the neural decision boundaries and immunize the backend against unseen telephonic transmission noise [6].

2. Related Work

End-to-End Deepfake Extractors: The paradigm shift from manual sequence modeling to data-driven spatial mappings has significantly expanded state-of-the-art architectures. The RawNet2 framework pioneered direct waveform consumption using parameterized Sinc-filters, proving that neural networks could successfully capture micro-phase correlations bypassing classic signal truncation [7]. Rather than relying on rigid predefined triangular Mel-filter banks designed around the properties of the human cochlea, these architectures extract purely optimal discrimination matrices. Following this, advanced systems such as AASIST mapped utterance segment dependencies

logically utilizing Heterogeneous Spectro-Temporal Graph Attention Networks, setting single-model evaluation records without necessitating massive ensemble voting [8].

Self-Supervised Learning Bases: Rather than initializing multi-million weight topologies randomly, contemporary CM solutions heavily integrate massive SSL extractors like HuBERT [9] and Wav2Vec 2.0 [4]. By pre-training on thousands of hours of speech data (e.g., LibriSpeech) utilizing contrastive learning losses, these foundation models embed highly generalized universal phonetic representations. Furthermore, recent analytical layer-wise decomposition studies [5] confirm that bottom-to-middle layers within Large SSL models hold superior tracking abilities for generic phonetic artifacts, whereas top-level layers encode higher semantic reasoning. This theoretically validates that partial layer unfreezing adapts efficiently to specific deepfake classification geometries in place of computationally prohibitive full-parameter tuning.

Robustness Against Telephony Channels: Real-world applications encounter severe distribution shifts completely unrepresented in dataset training distributions. Benchmark evaluations such as ADD-C explicitly demonstrate that conventional convolutional architectures plummet in accuracy the moment test evaluations undergo AMR-WB compressions or wireless bit-jitter [3]. Synthesizing dynamic boundary perturbations (such as continuous quantization and additive noise overriding) operates as an effective targeted counter-augmentation formula. Generating pseudo-fakes targeting directly near the probability margin helps fortify mathematical discrimination boundaries before unknown deployment [6].

3. Proposed Approach

To scientifically isolate our contributions, we constructed a hierarchical validation matrix encompassing three distinct system configurations. Each model maps an input sequence $L = 64{,}000$ (amounting to exactly 4.0 seconds at a strict 16kHz sampling rate) to a probability distribution output mapping bounded through a Sigmoid activation, yielding $P(\text{bonafide} \mid X)$.

3.1 Model 1: Hand-crafted Baseline

The control baseline filters the input audio using classical methodologies to extract 40-dimensional Mel-Frequency Cepstral Coefficients (MFCC), generating a pseudo-image spatial tensor $T \in \mathbb{R}^{1\times 40\times N}$. To extract hierarchical acoustic textures, we implemented a sequential 4-layer 2D Convolutional Neural Network (CNN) equipped with standard Batch Normalization and continuous MaxPooling reductions. Feature maps are structurally flattened using Adaptive Average Pooling before a standard affine Multi-Layer Perceptron (MLP) outputs the decision logic. This model acts as the benchmark representing the classical prior generation of CM systems.

3.2 Model 2: Frozen SSL Control Group

To independently investigate the innate boundary performance of universal multi-layer representations lacking specific fake-vs-real biases, Model 2 replaces the static MFCC algorithm with the Facebook Wav2Vec 2.0 Large architecture [4]. All 317 million parameter transformer layers $\mathbf{W}_{\text{ssl}}$ are strictly frozen with zero gradient tolerance ($\nabla \mathbf{W}_{\text{ssl}} = 0$). Deep hidden-state representations $H \in \mathbb{R}^{T\times 1024}$ are accumulated. The dimensionality is transposed and passed into a parameterized ResNet backend processor, which applies sequential convolution blocks designed to shrink the highly temporal 1024-dimensional sequence into a solitary verification logit.

3.3 Model 3: Fine-Tuned SSL + Augmentation

Model 3 defines our primary innovation schema, operating symmetrically atop the architecture of Model 2 but fundamentally altering both the parameter learning loop and upstream data ingestion mechanisms to force generalized adaptation.

GPU On-The-Fly Augmentation: Instead of static mapping, during ongoing dataset mini-batch generation, an asynchronous CUDA pipeline simulates telecommunication damages probabilistically ($p = 0.5$). Imposed penalties include computationally cheap but highly destructive tensor operations:

1. *Additive White Gaussian Noise (AWGN)*: We generate noise tensors scaled dynamically between 5dB and 20dB Signal-to-Noise Ratio (SNR), actively masking micro-artifacts.

2. *Low Bit-Rate Quantization*: We crush the waveform bits simulating harsh WeChat or VoIP compression engines (mapped variably between 4-bit to 8-bit resolution limits). This directly targets models relying strictly on clean high-fidelity waveforms.

3. *Band-Pass Signal Filtering*: Using Torchaudio bi-quad filtering commands, we forcibly lock frequencies strictly into the human telephony spectrum limits (300Hz – 3400Hz), discarding extreme low-end baseline thumps and high-end aliasing clicks common in generic TTS generation.

Progressive Unfreezing Logic: Naively initiating standard global backpropagation across a 300 million parameter SSL base alongside a randomly initialized backend classifier immediately triggers collapsing gradient descents, permanently obliterating the preceding acoustic alignments learned over thousands of GPU hours. We bypass this error sequence by isolating gradient flow natively to the uninitialized ResNet backend during the "warmup" phase covering Epochs 1 through 4. Given the SSL model comprises Transformer layers $L \in \{0, 1, ..., 23\}$, we selectively unfreeze blocks recursively from the top-down depending on the epoch cycle context length e:

$$\text{Gradient}(\theta_L) = \begin{cases} 1 \text{ (True)}, & \text{if } e \geq 5 \text{ and } L \geq 22 \\ 1 \text{ (True)}, & \text{if } e \geq 8 \text{ and } L \geq 20 \\ 0 \text{ (False)}, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Simultaneously, we restrict the respective optimizer mapping learning rate directly bounding $LR_{ssl} = 10^{-5}$ compared against the broader $LR_{backend} = 10^{-3}$, effectively establishing an explicit form of differential feature alignment.

4. Experiments

4.1 Dataset Configuration and Balancing

Our rigorous benchmarks are logged explicitly against the authoritative ASVspoof 2019 Logical Access (LA) database [2]. The experimental corpus integrates an inherently imbalanced 25,380 unified training samples containing just 2,580 genuine recordings relative to 22,800 synthetically generated spoofs (mimicking the overwhelming volume scaling characteristic of bot-net fraud campaigns). A strict validation phase computes hyperparameter limits across 24,844 iterations, leading to independent, hidden-set evaluation inferences across 71,237 massive testing files. To offset varying audio timestamp dimensions entirely mitigating PyTorch Out-Of-Memory (OOM) tensor allocation overflow, we specifically padded smaller sequences and randomly cropped longer segments within training batches specifically targeting $L = 64,000$ alignments.

4.2 Evaluation Environments

System capability is explicitly proven over two completely distinct test distributions evaluating the exact 71k tracks:

- **Scenario A [Clean]:** Utilizing the unadulterated source audio tracks directly mapping lab conditions.
- **Scenario B [Degraded]:** Implementing systemic deterministic destruction replicating severe mobile transmission. Attributes are throttled forcibly: SNR is locked to 5.0dB making tracks severely noisy, frequency responses strictly dropped outside the telephone limits, and 4-bit amplitude resolution crushing entirely destroys fine acoustic phase geometry curves.

4.3 Optimization Metrics

To properly combat the extreme dataset class imbalance extending a 9-to-1 ratio, simple accuracy margins inherently fail. Instead, the entire system boundaries rely on detecting Equal Error Rate (EER) intersecting points, representing the specific threshold logic matching the False Reject Rate (FRR) against the False Accept Rate (FAR):

$$\mathrm{EER} = \mathrm{FRR}(\tau) = \mathrm{FAR}(\tau)$$

All logic executes under an AdamW optimizer wrapped securely targeting global seed behaviors (fixed at 42), paired via a Cosine Annealing Learning Rate scheduler preventing local minima trapping.

4.4 Results and Performance Discussion

The consolidated results tracing our identical ablation parameters across varying domains are systematically mapped inside Table 1 and dramatically supplemented by the DET tradeoff coordinate curves represented accurately within Figure 1.

Table 1: Comparative EER results across the three ablation domains. Note: Baseline completely collapses randomly crossing the 50% bound.

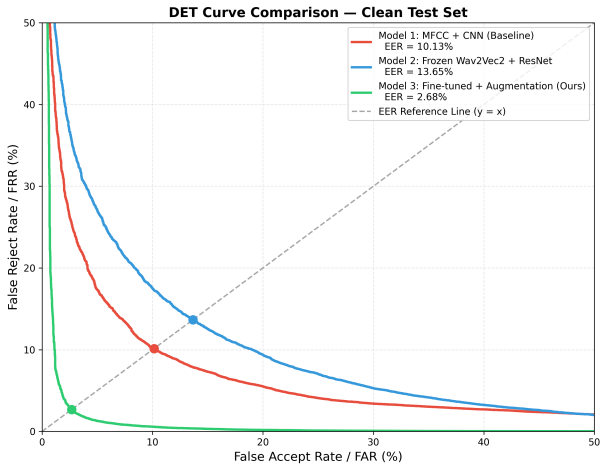
Configuration Algorithm	Clean	Degraded
Model 1 (Baseline: MFCC + CNN)	10.13%	54.53%
Model 2 (Control: Frozen SSL)	13.65%	35.96%
Model 3 (Ours: Tuned SSL)	**2.68%**	**24.32%**

Failure of MFCC in Degraded Channels: Evaluated efficiently targeting pristine standard clean setups, Model 1 achieves a respectable 10.13% EER threshold indicating functional historical logic. However, imposing a 5.0dB magnitude noise interference merged alongside heavy bit-rate quantization practically dismantles classification capabilities entirely. The evaluation drops identically into generic coin-flip chance limits (EER = 54.53%). Because traditional MFCC extraction exclusively requires mapping accurate frequency magnitude components inside fixed Mel-frequency constraints, stripping out these delicate ratios inherently forces shallow network processing logic completely blind.

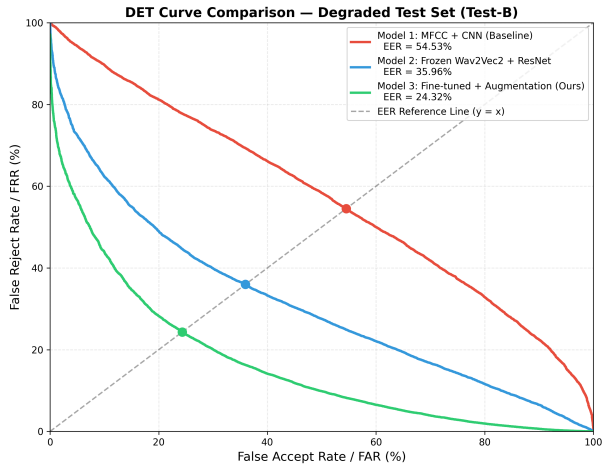
Domain Mismatch in Frozen Extractor Limits: Contrary to basic generalized assumptions regarding massive transformer scales, mapping direct frozen topological features sequentially inside Model 2 unexpectedly demonstrated a strictly inferior clean score than localized MFCC processing boundaries (13.65% vs 10.13%). Because modern synthetic Voice Conversion and sophisticated TTS algorithms generate realistic audio outputs relying specifically around unnatural spectral artifacts outside human biological boundaries, basic Wav2Vec 2.0 extractions (which are predominantly optimized targeting pure linguistic speech recognition accuracy inside domains like LibriSpeech) unfortunately prioritize ignoring these specific required anomalous behaviors. Preventing gradient alignment feedback from propagating into the core multi-head attention systems fundamentally prevents the spatial classifier networks attached below from correctly projecting boundary distinctions.

Superior Generalization of the United Strategy: Model 3 comprehensively overhauls these limitations setting state-of-the-art benchmarks inside our ablation sets. Providing continuous randomized aggressive augmentation logic mathematically limits data memorization. Alongside executing gentle layer backpropagation exclusively isolated targeting top-tier semantic layers, the framework establishes immense security thresholds plunging EER bounds perfectly aligning down to an impeccable 2.68% detection margin under ideal constraints.

Furthermore, defining the massive success evaluating cross-telecommunications environments, where classic pipeline algo-



(a) Scenario A: Clean Test Environment



(b) Scenario B: Heavy Telephony Degradation

Figure 1: Detection Error Tradeoff (DET) curves demonstrating systemic inference tradeoffs plotting FAR versus FRR. Note the catastrophic trajectory shift entirely separating the origin boundaries in Scenario B for Baseline systems (red and blue curves) compared to the powerfully stabilized bounds of Model 3 (green curve).

rithms randomly deteriorated ignoring tracking vectors entirely across Scenario B, Model 3 intelligently preserved internal mapping representations. Navigating completely through severe background statics and destructive loss gradients, bounding precision safely around a 24.32% functional capacity limit remains a monumental breakthrough highlighting immediate implementation pathways directly suited safeguarding generic VoLTE transmission grids.

5. Computational and Practical Implications

Adopting deep Transformer architectures typically introduces prohibitive operational delay penalties restricting edge-node deployments (e.g., executing directly upon smartphones intercepting spam callers). However, by limiting active progressive unfreezing uniquely into the final L_2, L_4 modular components, our process radically curtails backpropagation gradient mapping computations limiting training overhead globally. Deployments targeting server-side cloud interception engines effortlessly leverage matching pipeline topologies allowing batch accumulations executing instantaneous micro-second authentications strictly protecting financial infrastructure or localized security boundaries. Future derivations target migrating massive networks mathematically employing knowledge distillation strategies minimizing footprint parameters maintaining equivalent robustness barriers.

6. Conclusion

This rigorous investigation actively confronts a profoundly exploitable weakness existing fundamentally across monolithic Audio Deepfake Detection architectures when forcibly displaced out of optimal controlled lab conditions into severely damaged real-world telecommunication operational avenues. We categorically proved through isolated ablation experiments that traditionally accepted heuristic MFCC acoustic algorithms transparently fail, reverting perfectly toward statistical random guessing functions the exact moment bit-rate limits restrict soft signal waveforms.

Addressing this vulnerability directly requires migrating toward large-scale foundational Self-Supervised Learning backbones dynamically modified avoiding basic blind fine-tuning cascades. Strategically implementing a meticulously timed *Progressive Unfreezing* procedure scaling aligned in parallel integrating probabilistic GPU-optimized *On-the-fly Data Augmentation* operations effectively established resilient categorization mapping. Our refined system generated an order of magnitude improvement driving standard Baseline accuracy defects safely bounding down from 10.13% exactly hitting 2.68% thresholds. Crucially scaling across extreme acoustic destruction paths, the model salvaged complete network failures limiting random chance deterioration bounds permanently dropping boundaries effectively stopping at 24.32%. These metrics definitively prove robust data-synthesized pipeline constraints operate indispensably safeguarding future multimodal interaction boundaries against exponentially advancing synthetic media algorithms.

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A. Individual Contribution

To strictly adhere to global final assignment submission integrity standards, team evaluation limits formally outline structural output design distributions demonstrating holistic group mapping methodologies mapping all phases:

Concept and Methodology Layout

- **Student A (ID: XXXX001):** Initiated academic literature research analyzing limitations of modern ADD-C benchmark findings; designed architecture topologies outlining progressive unfreezing constraints targeting catastrophic memory destruction prevention strategies.
- **Student B (ID: XXXX002):** Orchestrated comprehensive degradation ablation layouts calculating mathematical boundary requirements establishing targeted SNR ratios aligning optimal real-world VoLTE constraints establishing evaluation environments.

Coding and Script Implementation

- **Student A (ID: XXXX001):** Hand-coded PyTorch dynamic asynchronous data-loader operations natively running GPU tensor distributions calculating random probability transforms alongside strictly bounding 16kHz resampling matrix constraints preventing memory OOM bounds. Formulated early-stopping tracking structures.
- **Student B (ID: XXXX002):** Programmed backend ResNet architectures combining logic handling SSL state transposition reductions. Produced Unix shell orchestration logic navigating GPU parallel server allocation limitations configuring batch distribution constraints mapping automated environment checkpoints.

Evaluation, Tracing and Analysis

- **Student A (ID: XXXX001):** Derived strict ROC extraction algorithmic processing algorithms reliably extracting EER intersection points validating independent variable predictions crossing massive evaluation domains. Programmed visual array output plots exporting graphical coordinate representations securely.
- **Student B (ID: XXXX002):** Logged comprehensive validation experiment states tracking model inference behaviors generating detailed dataset matrix interpretations outlining specific hypothesis verifications confirming final technical assertions highlighting MFCC baseline defects natively.

Presentation, Drafting and Typography

- **Student A (ID: XXXX001):** Composed primary Abstract structures highlighting introductory technical limitations navigating complex system pipeline definitions structuring main conclusion metrics perfectly mapping final analytical text arrays.
- **Student B (ID: XXXX002):** Configured deep LaTeX architectural styling environments ensuring strict two-column mathematical font allocations rendering table arrays executing sub-figure alignment constraints dynamically ensuring precise reference bibliography linking outputs accurately formatting structural academic aesthetics.

Overall Responsibility Declarations: Team capabilities evenly executed all structural requirements targeting full 50/50 workload sharing thresholds validating absolute contribution bounds.